

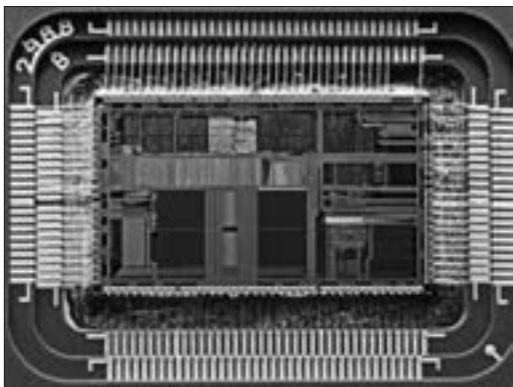
January: The i486

The first line of Intel i486 processors debuted in 1989. These were the second generations of the 32-bit x86 microprocessors and the first pipelined x86 architecture.

The i486 was named thus due to a court ruling that prohibited trade-marking numbers, like the 80486, to be used on products.

This processor was considered near-identical to the 386 with just a few evolutionary updates, the only real difference being its pipelining architecture.

The i486 was cloned by many other companies. Most of these clones were near-identical to the Intel offering, in spite of it being covered by a number of patents. Later on, the i486 boards also supported plug-



The pipelined architecture of the i486 processors

and-play features which was used in Windows 95 to make hardware installation easier.

In this decade, it seems, companies were constantly throwing products at the wall and seeing what would stick. It was also an era in which there were quite a few competing technologies vying for market share, and companies that stuck to open standards eventually won the battle.